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Joseph of Arimathea

A rich member of the council who went boldly to Pilate and laid Jesus in his own tomb.

Joseph of Arimathea was a wealthy member of the Jewish council and a secret disciple of Jesus, afraid of the other leaders. He had not agreed with the council's plan to kill Jesus. On the afternoon Jesus died, with the sabbath hours away, Joseph stepped out of the shadows and boldly asked Pilate for the body. With Nicodemus he wrapped it in linen and spices and laid it in his own new rock tomb. All four Gospels tell of him, and his tomb became the place where the resurrection was first announced.

At a glance

Name	Joseph of Arimathaea, in the KJV spelling
Home	Arimathaea, "a city of the Jews"; site uncertain (Luke 23:51)
Position	"An honourable counsellor" of the council (Mark 15:43)
Wealth	"A rich man" (Matthew 27:57)
Faith	A disciple, "but secretly for fear of the Jews" (John 19:38)
Key people	Jesus, Pontius Pilate, Nicodemus, Mary Magdalene
Main passages	Matthew 27:57–60; Mark 15:42–46; Luke 23:50–54; John 19:38–42

"Joseph of Arimathaea, an honourable counsellor ... went in boldly unto Pilate, and craved the body of Jesus."

Mark 15:43, KJV

The life of Joseph of Arimathea

The date follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view, AD 33. Joseph appears only on the day of Jesus' death, though Luke tells us how he had voted before.

Before the crucifixion <i>In the council</i>	● Refuses to consent Joseph is "a good man, and a just," who waits for the kingdom of God. He has not agreed with the council's plan and action against Jesus. <i>Luke 23:50-51</i>
c. AD 30 <i>Friday afternoon</i>	● Goes boldly to Pilate It is the day of preparation, the day before the sabbath. Joseph goes in to Pilate and asks for the body. Pilate checks with the centurion that Jesus is dead, then gives it to him. <i>Mark 15:42-45</i>
c. AD 30 <i>Before sunset</i>	● Takes down the body Joseph buys fine linen and takes the body down. With Nicodemus, who brings myrrh and aloes, he winds it in linen with the spices, as the Jews bury their dead. <i>Mark 15:46; John 19:38-40</i>
c. AD 30 <i>Before the sabbath</i>	● Lays Jesus in his tomb In a garden near the place of crucifixion, he lays Jesus in "his own new tomb, which he had hewn out in the rock." He rolls a great stone to the door and departs. <i>Matthew 27:59-60; John 19:41-42</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Arimathaea's location is uncertain. Many identify it with Ramathaim-zophim, Samuel's hometown in the hill country of Ephraim (1 Samuel 1:1), but this is not certain.

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- 1 Waited for the kingdom.** He was looking for the kingdom of God, like Simeon and Anna before him. *Mark 15:43; Luke 23:51*
 - 2 Dissented in the council.** He had not consented to the council's decision against Jesus. *Luke 23:51*
 - 3 Followed secretly.** For a time he kept his faith hidden, out of fear of the other leaders. *John 19:38*
 - 4 Went in boldly.** He risked his standing by asking Pilate for the body of a condemned man. *Mark 15:43*
 - 5 Gave his own tomb.** He laid Jesus in a new tomb where no one had yet been laid. *Matthew 27:60; Luke 23:53*
 - 6 Worked with Nicodemus.** Together they prepared the body with linen and spices. *John 19:39-40*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joseph of Arimathea.

Old Testament

Isaiah 53:9	"With the rich in his death," seen in the rich man's tomb
Deuteronomy 21:22-23	No body left on a tree overnight
Echo: Psalm 16:10	No corruption for the Holy One (Acts 2:27)

New Testament

Matthew 27:57-60; Mark 15:42-46; Luke 23:50-54; John 19:38-42	The burial
Matthew 28:1-6	The women find his tomb empty
Acts 13:29; 1 Corinthians 15:3-4	Laid in a sepulchre; buried and rose again
Echo: John 12:42-43	Rulers who believed but would not confess

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does each Gospel describe Joseph (Matthew 27:57; Mark 15:43; Luke 23:50-51; John 19:38)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Joseph stepped forward only after Jesus had died?
3. *Apply:* Joseph had been a secret disciple. Where do you keep your faith quiet, and what would one bold step look like?
4. *Apply:* Joseph gave his own tomb. What costly gift could you offer to Jesus or to someone in need this month?